

is primarily designed for open software repositories to enable reuse, sharing and remixing of new and existing code.

"While the policy is in place, it needs to be supported by appropriate technology infrastructure to create and grow a thriving open source community around Indian e-governance," a source told *Open Source For You*, with regard to the launch of the open source platform.



Similar to some of the popular repositories such as GitHub and SourceForge, the new offering will enable not just some government bodies but also a large number of software developers and corporates to develop and publish their code at a single place. The team behind the ongoing development is planning to divide the repository into two different segments—while one of its parts will be exclusive to government departments, another one will be open to the public.

Taking a cue from the policy designed by the Indian government, the US government also recently announced its Federal Source Code policy. But the US agencies will not get a distinct location like their counterparts in India to archive source code. This will make the Indian platform unique and a role model for some developed regions including the US, where the government is already embracing open source technologies.

Moreover, the new initiative by the Narendra Modi-led government would improve the efficiency of existing code that different departments are already using for various public programmes. Software developers and academic institutions could also help contribute to application testing and platform enhancements to deliver effective solutions.

US launches a policy to promote open source across federal agencies

In a move to enhance digitisation among its entities, the US government has launched its first-ever open source policy. The new policy mandates that all the federal agencies in the country have to release a portion of their custom code to the public.

Called the Federal Source Code policy, the initiative is aimed at helping government agencies reduce their expenses on various software development projects and improve access to

their custom application code. This emerged as a result of the plan that was revealed by the White House earlier this year.

"We're releasing the Federal Source Code policy to support improved access to custom-developed Federal source code. The policy, which incorporates feedback received during the public comment period, requires new custom-developed source code developed specifically by or for the Federal Government to be made available for sharing and reuse across all Federal agencies," US Chief Information Officer, Tony Scott, wrote in a blog post.

In addition to having a pool of source code to enable its sharing and reusability by government departments, the policy comes with a pilot programme that makes it necessary for the agencies to release at least 20 per cent of the new custom-developed code to the public. The US government is not demanding which portion of the code is to be made available in the public domain. However, federal agencies are recommending "transparency, participation and collaboration" in their projects.

"Agencies should calculate the percentage of source code released using a consistent measure — such as real or estimated lines of code, number of self-contained modules, or



cost — that meet the intended objectives of this requirement," the policy reads, describing the pilot programme.

This is not the first time that the Barack Obama-led government has opted for the open source way. The code of flagship public offerings such as We The People, Vets.gov and Data.gov is already available on GitHub.

"By opening more of our code to the brightest minds inside and outside of government, we can enable them to work together to ensure that the code is reliable and effective in furthering our national objectives," Scott added.

The US government is building Code.gov to support its policy. The new website will operate as an official place for all the open source code released by federal agencies in the future.

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